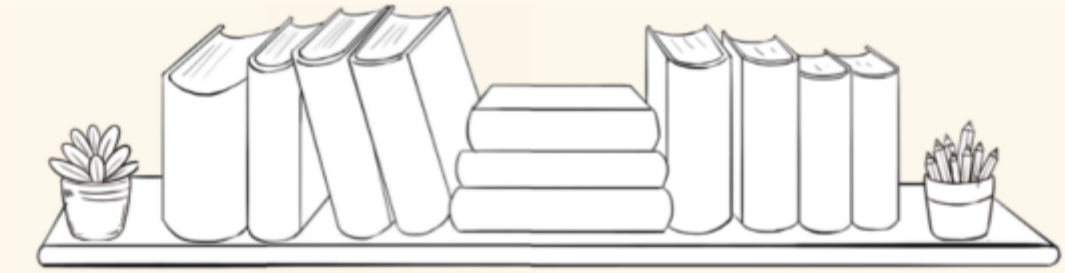
5 Book Uncle and Me

Warm up

Colour this 'shelfie' and write the names of your favourite books on the book spines.



Now, let us read a story about a girl named Yasmin and her favourite place to get books.

Watch me zigzag after school, every single afternoon, between the bus stop and Horizon Apartment Flats. It's where my best friend Reeni lives in 3B and I live in 3A.

Reeni and I wave to our friend Anil. He karate-blocks and punches at us through the bus window. It's his way of saying *Goodbye, see you tomorrow*.

The bus pulls off down the road.

"Bye, Yasmin," says Reeni.

"Bye, Reeni," I say.

She turns to go home. I go zig-zig-zag, off on my daily mission.

Mind the crooked tree. Mind the *istri* lady with her iron and heap of clothes. Mind the broken pavement and the pigeons cooling their feathers in mud puddles. Watch-watch-watch…

zigzag: to move forward by walking to the left and then to the right karate-blocks: stands in the way to stop an attack, using a martial arts technique crooked: bent or twisted
istri lady: the who irons clothes

And here it is! Book Uncle's Lending Library on the corner of St Mary's Road and 1st Cross Street, with books spread out on planks of wood and a small tin can for donations, just to help out, if anyone wants to.

Here is the sign in faded old letters:

Books. Free.
Give one.
Take one.
Read-Read-Read.

Perfect!

In all of India, could there be a better corner lending library than this?

"Hello, Yasmin-ma," says Book Uncle. "How is my Number One Patron?"

I don't know about Number One, but I'm sure I am Book Uncle's busiest patron as I mean to read one book every day. I started last year, right after I turned eight. That already feels like a billion years ago, because now I am past four hundred. Books, I mean.

How often does Yasmin visit the library? How do you know?

I return yesterday's floppy paperback graphic story. Book Uncle beams at me through glasses so fat they make his eyes extra big and extra smiley.

"Did you like it?" he asks. He really wants to know.

"Of course," I say. I always do. I always like the books he gives me.

He waves at the piles. "Take another, take another. Something different this time?"

He points to a thin book with a dark green cover.

I take a look. It seems a little skinny.

I pick it up. I open it. And for the first time ever, in all the time I've been getting books from Book Uncle, I am not sure.

Why is Yasmin hesitant to take the green book?

"It looks too easy," I say.

"Short and sweet," says Book Uncle. "An old Indian folk tale. You can read it three times in a day if you like."

patron: a person who is a loyal customer or supporter of your work floppy: hanging loosely paperback: a book with a thick paper cover beams: smiles widely skinny: very thin

I turn the book over and then over again.

"I can read bigger books," I say.

Book Uncle looks at me. He opens his mouth as if there is something he wants to say. Then, he closes it as if he has changed his mind.

Finally, when I think maybe he has forgotten I'm still there, he says, very softly. "Right book for the right person for the right day. As you know very well, that is my motto."

He's right. It is. It's a good motto. He has always given me the right book on the right day, hasn't he?

"I'll take it," I tell him.

I waste no time. As soon as I have stepped over the broken bits of pavement (which I really wish the city would fix so I could walk and read without worrying about where to put my feet), I start to read the book.

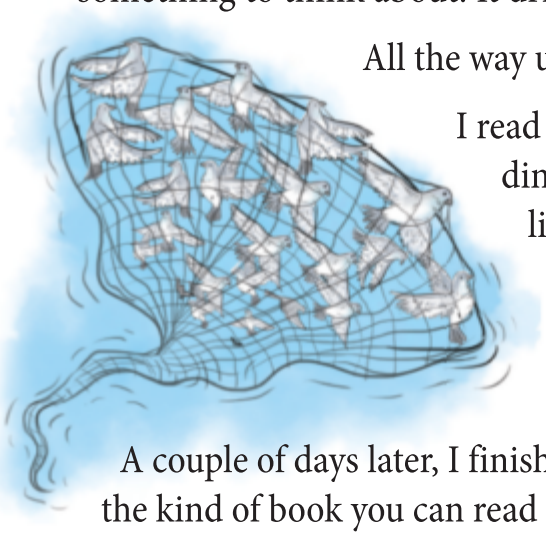
And I am sorry to say that I was right. It is a story for little children, about a king of doves who gets himself and all his followers stuck in a trap set by a hunter. At first, I am disappointed, but then I keep going to find out what happens to those doves.

There they are, caught in a net! I turn-turn-turn the pages. No escape, no escape. Try-try-try. Still no escape.

Will they save themselves?

Hmm. This may be a book for little children but still, it's giving me something to think about. It drives me crazy when a book does that.

Why do you think a few words in the story are repeated three times? How does it make you feel?



All the way up the stairs to 3A, I worry about those doves.

I read the book once straight through, after homework and dinner, and I find out that the dove king and all his followers lift the net together and do get free! I know, I know. I'm giving away the ending. But here's the thing. The point of a story is not the ending. The point is, what does it *mean*?

***

A couple of days later, I finish another book that Book Uncle gave me. It is a mystery—the kind of book you can read in one big gulp and it does not feel like work. Not like that

motto: a short sentence that expresses the aims and beliefs of a person

gulp: the amount swallowed at one time

dove book. Skinny as that one was, its story is still flapping around in my mind.

I get to the corner. The *istri* lady is yelling at her son. The buses are rattling down the road. It seems like a normal morning. But is it?

Because what I see stops me cold.

Book Uncle's place looks different. Book Uncle looks different.

"Good morning, Yasmin-ma," he says. He's not smiling.

The books are still in their boxes. He hasn't set them out yet, the way he does each morning.

"What's wrong?" I ask. He is still not smiling. It jumbles me up.

"I can't do this anymore," he says.

I stare at him. What does he mean?

"The mayor's office sent me a letter. They're telling me," he says, "that if I want to run my lending library here, I must get a permit."

A permit?

"Can't you get one?" I ask.

He shakes his head. "It costs too much—I can't afford it."

Book Uncle takes the book from my hand. He puts it in a box. He picks up the box. He carries it over the broken pavement and stacks it on top of the other boxes on his wooden cart. He does not even look at me. He rolls the cart up the road *ga-da-gadaa, goodoo-goodoo*. He does not look back.

The school bus is grinding its way towards my stop. I'd better go.

I don't want to get on that bus. I want to chase after Book Uncle. I want to say, "Wait! There must be some mistake!"

Can't anyone help him?

How do you think Yasmin feels at this point in the story?

adapted from *Book Uncle and Me*

Uma Krishnaswami is an Indian author who was born in 1956 in New Delhi. She has written many books for young readers such as *The Grand Plan to Fix Everything*, *Birds on the Brain* and *The Problem with Being Slightly Heroic*. This extract has been taken from her novel *Book Uncle and Me*. It is a charming story about how a young girl named Yasmin saves Book Uncle's lending library from shutting down.

flapping: moving wings quickly up and down yelling: shouting loudly rattling: moving while making a series of short, loud sounds stops (one) cold: makes one stop very suddenly jumbles: confuses permit: an official document that gives somebody the right to do something

In this section, we will:
- remember details about the story.
- infer and interpret the main ideas of the story.

(C-2.1, C-2.2, C-5.2)

Make connections

Map the story

Answer the following questions based on the story.

1. A large part of the story is set at Book Uncle's library. Pick out details from the story that the author uses to reveal the setting.

3 things around the library	
2 details about the library	
1 indication of where the library is	

2. Read the questions given below and tick (✔) the correct answer.
   a. A first-person narrative is a story where a character narrates the story from their point of view. Who is the narrator of this story?
      i. Yasmin ○ ii. Book Uncle ○ iii. the *istri* lady ○
   b. The plot of a story usually has a problem or a conflict. What is the conflict in this story?
      i. a conflict between Book Uncle and Yasmin ○
      ii. a conflict between Book Uncle and the Mayor's office ○
      iii. a conflict between Book Uncle and the books ○

Deep dive

Answer the following questions with reference to context.

1. *"Right book for the right person for the right day. As you know very well, that is my motto."*

RECALL	INFER	ANALYSE
a. Who said these lines and to whom?	b. Why did Book Uncle take some time before he said this to Yasmin?	c. Do you think the motto is a good one? Give reasons. d. Share an instance from your life when you found the right book on the right day.

2. *"Good morning, Yasmin-ma," he says. He's not smiling. The books are still in their boxes. He hasn't set them out yet, the way he does each morning. It jumbles me up.*

RECALL	INFER	ANALYSE
a. Where was Yasmin? Who greeted her?	b. Why did Yasmin say that the situation jumbled her up? Contrast it with what usually happened when she visited the library.	c. If you were in Book Uncle's position, what would you do to solve the problem?

Read, reflect and write

1. Are you older or younger than Yasmin? List any three observations about Yasmin's character and give evidence from the story.
2. The moral of a story is the message or lesson we get from it. What do you think is the moral of the story about the doves? Why do you think Book Uncle gave the book to Yasmin?
3. Prediction while reading is guessing what will happen next by using details or clues from the story, along with your own knowledge. The story you read in this lesson is an excerpt from the novel *Book Uncle and Me*. How do you think the story will end?

Read the novel *Book Uncle and Me* to figure out whether your prediction was correct or not.

Integrate

Let's build a class lending library. Each person could bring a book to gift to the library. Tag the books to show the book type or genre (refer to the 'Word Wall' section to learn more about different genres). With your classmates, design library cards that each of you could use to track the books you have read.

Word wall

In this section, we will:
- frame sentences using phrases from the story.
- learn to differentiate between different book genres. (C-4.2)

Phrases from the story

Build sentences of your own with the following phrases from the story.

daily mission	a billion years ago	stops me cold	jumbles me up

Book genres

The genre (pronounced as *zhahn-ruh*) of a book is the category or type of book.

Match the given genres to their descriptions.

1. fairy tale	a. a futuristic story that often deals with space travel and takes place on other planets, often involving aliens	◯
2. science fiction	b. a story where the characters are like real people and their problems are similar to those we face	◯
3. mystery	c. a story that is passed down from one generation to another, usually in a spoken form	◯
4. informational non-fiction	d. a story about a person's life and achievements, written by somebody else	◯
5. folk tale	e. a story of a person's life, written by that person	◯
6. realistic fiction	f. a story with fairies or magical creatures usually written for children	◯
7. biography	g. an interesting story where a character finds the truth behind a crime or unusual event with the help of clues	◯
8. drama	h. a story with a moral	◯
9. fable	i. a story written to be performed before an audience	◯
10. autobiography	j. writing that is mostly based on facts, like the content we often read in textbooks	◯

Give one example of a book from each genre that you have read.

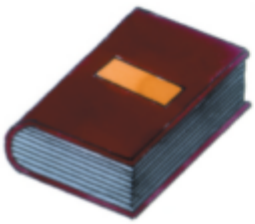
In this section, we will:
- learn how to use modals accurately based on their function.
- construct negative and interrogative sentences using modals.
- learn to apply the rules of subject–verb agreement. (C-3.4)

Grammar time

Modals

Read the given sentences.

- I can read bigger books.
- Will they save themselves?
- I must get a permit.



The words highlighted in pink and blue are both verbs. The verbs in blue are the main verbs. The verbs in pink are helping the main verbs, and are called modals.

ANCHOR CHART

MODAL VERBS IN ENGLISH

Modals are helping verbs that are used to express meanings such as **possibility**, **ability**, **permission**, **request** and **offer**. They cannot be used without main verbs.

CAN

expresses **ability**.

- I can speak two languages.

COULD

expresses **past ability**.

- I could climb a tree when I was young.

is used to **offer help**.

- I could help you carry those books.

WILL

is used to talk about the **future**.

- I will be in Colombo next week.

is used to **offer help**.

- I will help you with the homework.

WOULD

is used to **offer** something.

- Would you like a glass of water?

MAY

is used to ask **permission**.

- May I come home a little later?

expresses **possibility**.

- I may return home late.

MIGHT

expresses **slight possibility**.

- I might go to the moon soon!

MUST

expresses something **one has to do**.

- We must exercise to keep fit.

OUGHT TO

is used to say what's the **right thing** to do.

- I ought to call my parents now.

SHALL

is used to **make suggestions** (in questions).

- Shall we jog this evening?

show **intention**

- I shall keep my promise.

SHOULD

is used to give **advice**.

- You should eat dates to increase your iron intake.

1. Fill in the blanks using modal verbs. Some blanks will allow more than one modal as correct answers.

a. You eat too many sweets. You _____ eat a more balanced diet.

b. _____ you like tea or coffee?

c. Last year, I _____ jump higher than Zenia. This year, she stood first in the high jump event.

d. It's good to know that you enjoy reading. I _____ give you a book of exciting adventure stories.

e. I've forgotten my sharpener at home. _____ I borrow yours?

f. Father can't find his spectacles. He was at the office all morning and _____ have left them there.

Position of modal verbs in statements, negative statements and questions

	Word order	Examples
+ **Statements**	subject + modal + main verb	Dorje can swim fast. The cab will arrive on time.
− **Negative statements**	subject + modal + *not* + main verb	Dorje cannot swim fast. The cab will not arrive on time.
? **Questions**	modal + subject + main verb	Can Dorje swim fast? Will the cab arrive on time?

2. Change each of these sentences into a negative statement and a question. One has been done for you.

a. They can climb the mountain.

Negative statement: They cannot climb the mountain.

Question: Can they climb the mountain?

b. We will go to Mumbai next week.

c. Geeta should wear her cap.

d. They will walk to school tomorrow onwards.

e. Meryl can play the sarangi.

f. I should go to the hospital immediately.

Subject–verb agreement

ANCHOR CHART

Rules of subject–verb agreement

Subjects and verbs must agree in number.

A singular subject needs a singular verb.

- She turns to go home.

A plural subject needs a plural verb.

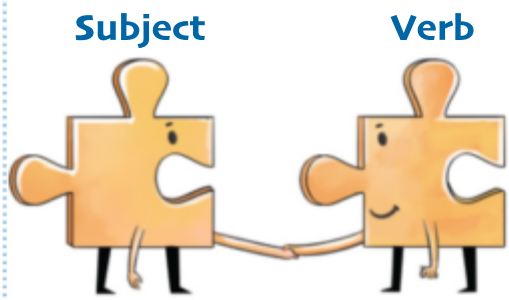
- The buses are rattling down the road.

Titles of books and movies need a singular verb.

- *The Hunter and the Doves* is Yasmin's favourite book.

Two subjects joined by *and* need a plural verb.

- Reeni and I wave to our friend Anil.



Words like *spectacles, trousers* and *scissors* need a plural verb.

- Book Uncle's spectacles have thick lens.

A collective noun needs a singular verb.

- A pile of books is on the table.

The pronouns *anybody*, *anyone*, *everybody*, *nobody*, *somebody*, *anything*, *everyone*, *no one* and *someone* need a singular verb.

- There is a small tin can for donations, just to help out, if anyone wants to.

1. Circle the correct form of the verb for each of the sentences given below.

a. *One Hundred and One Dalmatians* is / are an animated adventure film.

b. Everyone is / are special.

c. The mice scamper / scampers all over the barn.

d. My teeth sparkle / sparkles.

e. A New Zealander and a Nepali Sherpa was / were the first mountaineers to reach the summit of Mount Everest.

f. Your scissors is / are not as sharp as they used to be.

g. Mathematics is / are the study of numbers.

h. Do / does you understand how to make subjects and verbs agree?

2. Write an example sentence for each of the subject–verb agreement rule you learnt above.

In this section, we will:
- learn the correct usage of commas. (C-3.4)

Punctuation

Use of commas

We use a comma to separate a list of things.

- Yasmin borrowed a graphic novel, a storybook, an autobiography and two children's magazines from the lending library.

Sometimes a sentence tells us two things. One is the main idea that is important to a sentence, and the other is the less important part of the sentence. We use a pair of commas in the middle of a sentence to set off words that are not essential to the meaning of the sentence.

- Book Uncle, *who ran a lending library in town*, was sent a letter from the mayor's office.

In the sentence given above, the main or essential idea can be expressed using the sentence:

- Book Uncle was sent a letter from the mayor's office.

Even if we leave out the words *who ran a lending library in town*, the sentence is complete. The less important or non-essential idea, *who ran a lending library in town*, is marked off with commas.

Let's look at a few more examples. Notice how the sentences remain complete even if we were to omit the less important idea marked off with the commas.

Examples:

- The mango, *my favourite fruit*, is grown all over India.
- Tina, *my little sister*, enjoys reading books.
- My friend, *who lives in Jaffna*, is coming to visit me.

Read the sentences given below and separate the main idea from the less important one by using commas in the right places.

1. My sister who is five years older than me is in Class X.
2. Apples especially the green ones are my favourite.
3. My school which is a hundred years old is the oldest school in town.
4. Samira the captain of our team won the best player award.
5. Our neighbour's puppy a three-month old beagle is digging up the flower bed.

In this section, we will:
- complete the missing part of a story using the skill of prediction.
(C-2.2, C-3.2, C-3.3)

Write well

Story writing: Prediction

Read the extract given below from the last chapter of the novel *Book Uncle and Me*.

In just a few days, a big crowd shows up on the corner of St Mary's Road and 1st Cross Street to celebrate the now officially permitted Book Uncle's Free Lending Library.

There are so many people that the city had to close the road to cars and buses and autorickshaws, bikes and motorbikes and scooters and anything else with wheels.

And here is Book Uncle. He cannot stop smiling. He sits in a chair next to his books. They are laid out in perfect stacks. The fruit man and his wife have helped Book Uncle set up this fine new reopened lending library.

Look at the pavement—newly patched! Nice and even. No broken bricks.

And just look at the new and improved sign, re-lettered and sharpened up.

Books. Free.

Give one.

Take one.

Read-Read-Read.

Use your imagination to write the missing middle part of the story where Yasmin helps to save Book Uncle's library. Draw an illustration to depict the turning moment or climax of the story.

In this section, we will:
- listen carefully to complete the missing details.
- solve problems by expressing one's opinions and views.
(C-1.1, C-1.3)

Listen and speak well

1. Listen to the audio and complete the given sentences using appropriate words.

a. Another name for a bookmobile is _____.

b. The earliest form of book libraries appeared in England and United States in the form of book wagons drawn by _____.

c. Bookmobiles were motorized with the invention of _____.

d. During World War II, jeeps and trucks were converted into bookmobiles to distribute reading material in _____.

e. Besides trucks and jeeps, different _____ such as bikes, bicycles, boats, and even hot air balloons have been used over the years as bookmobiles.

f. The Boat Library Services in India was started in _____ to instil reading interest in the rural people.

g. In 2021, a floating library was launched on Kolkata's _____.

2. **At the end of the story, we see how Yasmin is wondering how to solve Book Uncle's problem and prevent the lending library from shutting down. Are you also a problem solver like Yasmin? Can you help people find the best solutions in difficult situations? Let's play a game to find out.**

Given below is a grid with different problems. Make groups of five players and take turns to roll the dice. The player who rolls the dice moves the counter to the square indicated by the number on the dice. Once their counter lands on a square, they should read out the problem mentioned in it out loud. The other players will take turns to give the best solutions for the problem. The person who moved the counter decides which player gave the best solution. Then, the other players also take turns to move their counters and the game continues. The player who gives the highest number of best solutions wins the game.

19 I overheard someone making fun of me.	20 Someone else took the credit for something I did.	21 Someone is constantly interrupting me in a group conversation.	22 There is a large pile of rubbish on the road outside my house.	FINISH
18 I want to give a birthday gift to a friend but I don't have enough money.	17 I have lost my notebook.	16 A family member is feeling unwell and there is no one other than me at home.	15 My parents are hesitant to send me on a school trip.	14 My friend borrows my books but does not return them.
10 I want to do something for climate change but don't know what.	11 I unknowingly made a mean joke about my friend, and they felt bad.	FREE PASS!	12 My best friend moved far away.	13 The loud music from my neighbour's house distracts me while I am studying.
9 My elderly neighbour finds it difficult to hear what I say.	8 In a group project, a person is not contributing at all, and is being lazy.	7 One of my classmates bullies other children.	6 I quarrelled with my best friend.	5 The fire alarm goes off at school.
START	1 I am new at school and don't have friends yet.	2 I missed the school bus.	3 I have lost my way home.	4 I forgot my lunch box at home.